CHAPTER 8 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

Lincoln's Assassination

Five days after the surrender, the man who had promised “malice toward none” was gone. April 1865.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

Five days after the surrender, the man who had promised “malice toward none” was gone. April 1865.

How much does history depend on a single person — and what is lost when that person is suddenly taken?

Good Friday

APRIL 14, 1865

The war was all but over. Richmond had fallen, Lee had surrendered, and a weary, hopeful Lincoln had just been reelected to guide the nation's healing. On the evening of April 14, 1865, he went to Ford's Theatre in Washington to relax.

There, actor and Confederate sympathizer John Wilkes Booth shot the president. Lincoln died the next morning. It was the first assassination of an American president — and it came at the worst possible moment.

“The Assassination of President Lincoln” at Ford’s Theatre, April 14, 1865 — hand-colored lithograph, Currier & Ives, public domain (Library of Congress).

The Shot That Shook the Nation

FORD'S THEATRE · APRIL 14, 1865

Booth waited for a laugh line, slipped into the president's box, and fired a single shot before leaping to the stage below. Later prints dramatized the moment for a shocked public.

“The Assassination of President Lincoln” at Ford's Theatre, April 14, 1865 — hand-colored lithograph, Currier & Ives, public domain (Library of Congress).

A City in Mourning

WASHINGTON, D.C., APRIL 1865

Ford's Theatre, draped in black and guarded, in the days after the assassination. The nation's joy at the war's end turned overnight into grief.

Ford's Theatre, draped in mourning after the assassination, Washington, D.C. — photograph, 1865, public domain (Library of Congress).

“With Malice Toward None”

THE MAN WHO WAS LOST

Just weeks earlier, in his Second Inaugural Address, Lincoln had laid out his vision for peace: “With malice toward none, with charity for all … let us strive on to finish the work … to bind up the nation's wounds.”

He wanted a reconstruction that was firm but forgiving — one that would bring the South back while securing freedom for the formerly enslaved. His unique authority, political skill, and moral standing might have steered that difficult path.

Ford's Theatre, draped in mourning after the assassination, Washington, D.C. — photograph, 1865, public domain (Library of Congress).

A Harder Road for Reconstruction

THE CONSEQUENCE

Power now passed to Vice President Andrew Johnson — a Southern Unionist who lacked Lincoln's vision, skill, and commitment to Black freedom. Johnson clashed bitterly with Congress, was impeached, and oversaw a Reconstruction that failed to protect the rights it had promised.

Historians call this a question of consequence: Lincoln's death didn't just end a life — it removed the one leader who might have guided Reconstruction toward a more just outcome. The assassin's bullet shaped the next twelve years, and beyond.

Turning points, 1863–65 — map, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).

Trace the Consequences

YOUR TURN

You'll read Lincoln's own words about the peace he wanted and practice reasoning about consequence — asking how his death changed the course of Reconstruction.